STUDY SHEET · SOCIOLOGY

Sociopolitical context of business

Ten sessions in one document: theories, thinkers, concepts and examples, with the comparisons that come up in exams.

Tipoki

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Sessions 1 to 10 · Sociology, society and business

> *Sociology asks **why people act as they do in groups** and how society shapes, and is shaped by, the individuals in it. The sessions move from the discipline's founding ideas, through socialisation, control, inequality and culture, to the power of institutions and the liquid world we live in now.*

01 Why and what sociology

The sociological imagination and the great paradigms.

Sociology	The systematic study of human society and social interactions.
Society	A large grouping sharing a territory, one political authority and dominant cultural expectations.
Sociological imagination	**C. Wright Mills**: linking personal biography to history and social structure. Many **personal troubles** are really **public issues**.
Quantitative / qualitative	Statistics and surveys find patterns (the **what**); interviews and focus groups reveal meanings (the **why**).

Two ways of describing the sociological perspective: **seeing the strange in the familiar** (Macionis) and **seeing the general in the particular** (Berger).

THE FOUNDERS

Thinker	Key idea
Auguste Comte	Coined "sociology" (1824). Positivism, "Order and Progress"; social **statics** (what holds society together) and **dynamics** (how it changes).
Ibn Khaldun	14th century, *Muqaddimah*: the rise and fall of civilisations, driven by **asabiyyah** (group spirit).
Harriet Martineau	Translated Comte; *Society in America*; defended racial and gender equality.
Karl Marx	Class conflict between bourgeoisie and proletariat; economics drives change.
Émile Durkheim	Social cohesion = integration + regulation; suicide as a **social fact**.
Max Weber	Four types of social action; Protestant ethic; rationality and bureaucracy.
George H. Mead	Founder of symbolic interactionism: actors give meaning to actions.
Talcott Parsons / Robert Merton	Functionalists; Merton adds manifest and latent functions, dysfunctions and strain.

THREE PARADIGMS (AND A FOURTH)

Paradigm	Society is…	Metaphor	Level
Functionalism	a stable system of interdependent parts producing order	an **organism**	macro
Conflict theory	a struggle over scarce resources, dominant vs dominated	a battlefield	macro
Symbolic interactionism	created and recreated through meaningful everyday interaction	**construc-tivism**	micro
Postmodernity	fragmented, plural, with no single truth	a **river**	—

WEBER'S FOUR TYPES OF SOCIAL ACTION

Type	Question asked
Instrumental rationality	What is the most effective way to achieve my goal?
Value rationality	What should I do according to my principles?
Affectual action	What do my emotions lead me to do?
Traditional action	What do I normally do, out of habit or custom?

Manifest functions are intended and recognised; **latent** functions are unintended and unrecognised. **Bauman** describes modernity shifting from **solid** to **liquid**: stable institutions and life paths give way to flexible, transient, precarious ones.

02 Socialisation, roles and identities

How we become members of society.

Socialisation	Social and cultural learning through which we internalise a culture and its roles.
Primary / secondary	Primary: early learning from **significant others**. Secondary: later learning, where the **generalised other** opens us to the world.
Resocialisation	Replacing earlier socialisation, typical of **total institutions** (prison, military, mental institution).
Social role	"A standardised response to a standardised expectation of social behaviour." **Role conflict** comes from contradictory expectations.
Cognitive dissonance	**Festinger**: discomfort from holding two conflicting beliefs. One way out: trivialising ("it's not such a big deal").

SELF AND SOCIETY

Author	Concept
Mead	**Role-taking** in three stages: preparatory, **play** (one significant other at a time), **game** (many roles and the rules of the generalised other).
Cooley	The **looking-glass self**: self-image built on how we think others see us.
Harlow	Monkeys with a **cloth mother** and a **wire mother** (1962): affectional contact is crucial.
Bronfenbrenner	Bioecological model: development shaped by nested environmental systems.
Veblen	**Conspicuous consumption**: high-status groups flaunt goods, lower groups emulate.

Agents of socialisation: family, school, peers, mass media, religion, workplace, the internet. “Digital natives” is **Marc Prensky**’s term (2001); **deaths of despair** (Case, Deaton) and Kahneman’s “social pain is real for the brain” remind us how much belonging matters.

03 Institutions, deviance and social control

Norms, sanctions, and who gets labelled.

A **social institution** is a relatively stable pattern of conduct based on socially accepted definitions of appropriate behaviour. Five traits: **externality**, **objectivity**, **coercion**, **moral authority**, **historicity**.

Deviance is socially constructed: people are labelled deviant according to cultural norms. **Social control** is the system of sanctions (preventive, repressive, exemplary), exercised by persuasion or by coercion.

EXPLAINING DEVIANCE

Theory	Core claim
Functionalist	Deviance clarifies rules, unites the group and promotes change. **Durkheim**: rooted in rapid change and weak integration.
Strain (Merton)	Strain when goals cannot be reached through culturally approved means.
Conflict	Norms and laws reflect the interests of the powerful; **cultural hegemony** makes the status quo seem natural.
Differential reinforcement	Conventional and deviant behaviour are learned through the same processes.
Rational choice	Deviance occurs when benefits are judged to outweigh risks.
Social bond	Deviance is likelier when ties to society are weakened.
Labelling	Control agencies label people, who accept the label and act accordingly.

Surveillance and the digital self

Foucault: power, knowledge and social control are intertwined. The **panopticon** makes inmates feel permanently watched; schools, hospitals and prisons are **disciplinary institutions**. Today: Snowden’s NSA revelations, China’s **social credit system**, and under-16 social media bans in Australia (December 2025) and under-15 in France (July 2026).

DARK PATTERNS

Pattern	What it does
Nagging	Repeated requests that keep coming back (“Rate this app?”).
Obstruction	An unwanted path made deliberately hard (cancelling a subscription).
Sneaking	Key information hidden or delayed (hidden fees).
Interface interference	Layout privileges one option: bright “Accept all”, greyed “Reject”.
Forced action	An unwanted action required to proceed (create an account to check out).
Confirmshaming	Guilt-tripping wording on the decline option.
Scarcity and urgency	Fake countdowns, “only 2 left”.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Dark-pattern test: *if the user fully understood what was happening, would they still make the same choice?*
- A digital **nudge** steers choices through the way options are presented.

04 Social stratification

Who gets what, and why it lasts.

Social stratification	The hierarchical organisation of society into unequal strata, based on **material** resources (wealth, income) and **symbolic** ones (power, education, status).
Caste system	Closed stratification: status ascribed at birth, no social mobility.
Meritocracy	The ideal that positions are earned by qualifications and performance.

Thinker	On stratification
Marx	Class defined by ownership: capital against labour.
Weber	Three dimensions: **class, status and power**. **Social closure** lets groups control access to valued positions.
Davis and Moore	Functionalists: unequal rewards fill the most important jobs.
Ridgeway	**Status construction theory**: neutral differences become tied to unequal competence through everyday interaction, a self-fulfilling prophecy.
Bauman	**Flawed consumers**: people unable to consume end up as outsiders.

BOURDIEU (*DISTINCTION*, 1979)

Capital	Content
Economic	Money and property.
Cultural	Embodied (how you speak and behave), objectified (books, art), institutionalised (degrees).
Social	Networks and useful relationships.
Symbolic	Prestige and recognition.

The **habitus** is the set of ingrained, unconscious dispositions and tastes shaped by class and upbringing; "good taste" is socially learned, not personal.

05 Gender stratification and the manosphere

Sex / gender	Sex is biological and anatomical; **gender** is the social construction of femininity and masculinity.
Patriarchy	A system in which cultural, political and economic structures are controlled by men. **Walby**: **private** (household) vs **public** (labour market, state) patriarchy.
Judith Butler	Gender is not what you are but what you do: **performance**.
Labour market segmentation	Division of the job market into separate, unequal segments. **Pay equity**: wages should reflect the job's worth.

GENDER BIASES AT WORK

Bias	Meaning
Likeability	Women expected to be kind rather than assertive.
Attribution	Success explained by luck or help instead of skill.
Performance	Men hired on potential, women on proven performance.
Parenting	Time off signals less commitment.
Affinity	Gravitating to people like us ("us vs them").

The **manosphere** (Andrew Tate, GamerGate in 2014) promotes masculinity, misogyny and opposition to feminism. **Unpaid care work**: about 16.4 billion hours a day worldwide, 76% done by women. Intersex people (about 1.7%) and the **hijra**, a legally recognised third gender in India, show that the binary is a cultural construct.

06 Race, discrimination and algorithmic bias

Race	A socially constructed category created by collective agreement and imposition. **Ethnic group**: distinguished by cultural or national characteristics.

Dominant / subordinate group	The first has the greatest power and resources; a **minority** is defined by subordination, not only by numbers.
Racism	Attitudes, beliefs and practices justifying superior treatment of one group. **Apartheid** is its legal form.
Prejudice / stereotype	Prejudice: negative attitude from faulty generalisation. **Stereotype**: overgeneralisation, positive or negative.
Discrimination	Harmful actions by the dominant group: **individual** (one-on-one) or **institutional** (everyday organisational practices).
Scapegoating	Unfairly blaming a group to deflect responsibility.
Intersectionality	How overlapping identities (race, gender, class) combine to shape privilege and disadvantage.

Theory	Claim
Adorno	The **authoritarian personality** (F scale): rigid conventionalism, obedience to authority, aggression toward non-conformers.
Cultural theory	Prejudice is a cultural pattern embedded in values and traditions.
Race-conflict theory	Racism as a struggle for power and resources.
Charles Mills	The Social Contract is really a **Racial Contract**.

Algorithmic bias

- **Joy Buolamwini**: face recognition performs worse on darker-skinned women.
- **COMPAS**: a justice risk algorithm that labelled Black defendants "high-risk" more often.
- **Amazon's recruiting engine** (2014–15) did not rate candidates in a gender-neutral way.
- Regulation: the **EU AI Act** treats AI recruiting as high-risk; the Netherlands keeps a public algorithm registry (December 2022).

07 Culture and cultural processes

Culture is shared ways of thinking, feeling and acting that give identity and make survival possible. **Material** culture is physical objects and technology; **non-material** culture is values, beliefs, norms, language and symbols.

ELEMENTS OF CULTURE

Element	Meaning
Values	Criteria for acceptable or unacceptable, with a moral connotation.
Beliefs	Statements held as true, with less critical thinking.
Norms	**Mores** (right/wrong), **folkways** (polite/rude), laws. **Prescriptive**: "do..."; **proscriptive**: "don't...".
Language	The fundamental mechanism of cultural reproduction. **Sapir-Whorf**: language shapes (weak) or determines (strong) thought.

CULTURAL VARIETY

Concept	Meaning
Subculture	Values and styles distinguishing a group within the dominant culture.
Counterculture	Rejects dominant values: hippies, beats, punks.
High vs popular culture	Elite forms tied to the upper classes vs forms enjoyed by the masses.
Cultural lag (Ogburn)	Material culture changes faster than values, norms and institutions.
Ethnocentrism / relativism	Judging others by one's own standards vs not judging any culture by external parameters.
Etic / emic (Harris)	The observer's external view vs the group's internal view.

A "third way" on cultural difference: respect and intercultural dialogue starting from a basic consensus on **human rights**. Cultural shock is the disorientation of meeting unfamiliar symbols, values and ways of life.

08 Health, illness and disability

WHO definition (1946)	Complete physical, mental and social well-being, not merely absence of disease.
Biomedical model	Disease as a bodily malfunction diagnosed and treated by doctors.
McKeown	Falling mortality came mainly from better nutrition and living standards, not medicine.
Illich	*Medical Nemesis*: **iatrogenesis** comes in three forms: clinical (harm from treatment), social (medicalisation), cultural (loss of ability to cope alone).
Sick role (Parsons)	The sick are exempt from duties but must seek help and want to get well.
Wilkinson and Pickett	*The Spirit Level*: inequality worsens outcomes in rich societies.
Harvard Study of Adult Development	Running since 1938: the strongest predictor of long-term health is **good relationships**.

TWO MODELS OF DISABILITY

Medical model	Social model
An individual defect to be fixed or cured.	Disability comes from **social barriers**. UPIAS (1976): social oppression on top of impairment; Mike Oliver (1983) made the contrast explicit.

09 Power, social change and reproduction

Social reproduction is how societies transmit structures, norms and inequalities from one generation to the next; Bourdieu's **symbolic violence** imposes the dominant culture as natural or neutral.

WEBER'S THREE TYPES OF AUTHORITY

Type	Legitimacy rests on…
Legal-rational	Rules, laws and bureaucracy.
Charismatic	A leader's extraordinary personal qualities.
Traditional	Custom: "it has always been so".

CROWDS AND MOVEMENTS

Theory	Claim
Contagion (Le Bon)	Crowds make individuals lose rational control.
Emergent norm	Crowds define the situation and create new norms on the spot.
Convergence	People with shared goals come together.
Social movement	An organised collective effort to promote or resist change.

Giddens' structuration theory: structure and agency shape each other. **Paul Lafargue**, in *The Right to Be Lazy* (1880), argued against the "right to work".

10 Postmodernity and consumer society

FROM COMMUNITY TO INDIVIDUALISATION

Thinker	Idea
Tönnies	**Gemeinschaft** (community) vs **Gesellschaft** (society).
Durkheim	**Mechanical** solidarity (similarity) vs **organic** solidarity (interdependence); **anomie** when rules weaken.
Weber	**Disenchantment of the world**: rationalisation replaces magical explanations.
Beck	**Risk society** and individualisation.
Lyotard	The postmodern condition: incredulity toward grand narratives.
Baudrillard	Simulation and **hyperreality**.
Habermas	Modernity as an unfinished project.
Lasch	*The Culture of Narcissism*.
Bauman	**Liquid modernity**.

Detraditionalisation: traditions lose authority and people build "DIY biographies". The same forces explain why belonging, status and identity are increasingly built through consumption and online life.

EXAM REFLEXES

- For each theory, know its **metaphor**, its **level** (macro or micro) and one **example**.
- Compare rather than list: functionalism vs conflict, mechanical vs organic, solid vs liquid.
- Link concepts across sessions: Bourdieu's capitals, Weber's class-status-power, Bauman's flawed consumers.